

1976 年巴菲特致股东的信

翻译: Rick http://blog.sina.com.cn/s/blog_a3453d2201015yh2.html

To the Stockholders of Berkshire Hathaway Inc,

After two dismal years, operating results in 1976 improved significantly. Last year we said the degree of progress in insurance underwriting would determine whether our gain in earnings would be "moderate" or "major." As it turned out, earnings exceeded even the high end of our expectations. In large part, this was due to the outstanding efforts of Phil Liesche's managerial group at National Indemnity Company.

致伯克希尔股东：

两年的糟糕业绩之后，1976 年的经营业绩大幅改善。在去年的年报里，我们曾提到承保业务的进展将决定我们今年的业绩是“还行”，亦或是“很不错”。最后的事实表明，业绩远超我们的预期。在很大程度上，这归功于 Phil 所领导的国民赔偿公司优秀的运营业绩。

In dollar terms, operating earnings came to \$16,073,000, or \$16.47 per share. While this is a record figure, we consider return on shareholders' equity to be a much more significant yardstick of economic performance. Here our result was 17.3%, moderately above our long-term average and even further above the average of American industry, but well below our record level of 19.8% achieved in 1972. Our present estimate, subject to all the caveats implicit in forecasting, is that dollar operating earnings are likely to improve somewhat in 1977, but that return on equity may decline a bit from the 1976 figure.

以绝对值衡量，1976 年的营业利润为 1607 万美元，合每股约 16.47 美元。这是一个创历史新高的数字，但是我们认为 ROE 是个更好的衡量业绩的指标。1976 年，我们的 ROE 是 17.3%，比我们长期平均水平要好，更高于美国产业的平均水平，但是比我们 1972 年取得的最高业绩记录 19.8% 要低。综合目前的情况，1977 的营业利润在绝对值上会比 1976 年要高，但是从 ROE 的角度看，可能要下降一些。

Textile Operations

Our textile division was a significant disappointment during 1976. Earnings, measured either by return on sales or by return on capital employed, were inadequate. In part, this was due to industry conditions which did not measure up to expectations of a year ago. But equally important were our own shortcomings.

纺织业务

1976 年我们的纺织业务表现令人失望。无论是净利润率，还是投入资本收益率（ROCE），都处于较低水平。造成这个状况的部分原因是纺织行业的景气度未达到我们的预期，但是同样重要的原因是我们自身也存在一些问题。

Marketing efforts and mill capabilities were not properly matched in our new Waumbec operation. Unfavorable manufacturing cost variances were produced by improper evaluation of machinery and personnel capabilities. Ken Chace, as always, has been candid in reporting problems and has worked diligently to correct them. He is a pleasure to work with—even under difficult operating conditions. While the first quarter outlook is for red ink, our quite tentative belief is that textile earnings in 1977 will equal, or exceed modestly, those of 1976.

在我们新收购的工厂里，营销努力和产能没有很好地匹配。对机器设备和员工素质不合理的评估（可能指收购时，rick）导致了生产成本的上升。Ken，总是会将问题报告给我，他正在努力工作，改进这些问题。即使在情况很糟的情况下，和 Ken 一起工作也是令人愉快的事情。虽然 1977 年第一季度很有可能亏损，我们还是预期 1977 年纺织行业的利润将等于或者超过 1976 年。

Despite disappointing current results, we continue to look for ways to build our textile operation and presently have one moderate-size acquisition under consideration. It should be recognized that the textile business does not offer the expectation of high returns on investment. Nevertheless, we maintain a commitment to this division—a very important source of employment in New Bedford and Manchester—and believe reasonable returns on average are possible.

尽管目前纺织行业的业绩令人失望，我们仍在努力寻找改善我们业绩的方法。同时，我们也在考虑一个中等规模的收购。我们必须认识到：纺织业务不会提供高额的投资回报率。然而，我们承诺继续保留这个业务部门：因为它们为 New Bedford 和 Manchester 地区提供了重要的就业机会。我们相信我们的纺织业务会取得一个合理的回报。

Insurance Underwriting

Casualty insurers enjoyed some rebound from the disaster levels of 1975 as rate increases finally outstripped relentless cost increases. Preliminary figures indicate that the stockholder owned portion of the property and casualty industry had a combined ratio of 103.0 in 1976, compared to 108.3 in 1975. (100 represents a break-even position on underwriting—and higher figures represent underwriting losses.) We are unusually concentrated in auto lines where stock companies had an improvement from 113.5 to 107.4. Our own overall improvement was even more dramatic, from 115.4 to 98.7.

承保业务

由于保费费率的上升最终超过了不断上涨的成本的涨幅，承保意外险的保险公司从 1975 年灾难性的业绩中恢复过来。初步的数据显示，财险和意外伤害保险行业的综合费用比率从 1975 年的 108.3 下降到了 1976 年的 103.0 (100 表示承保业务盈亏平衡，超过 100 表示承保业务亏损)。我们的产品业务线主要集中于车险，行业(不知道这里的 **stock company** 是何意?)的综合费用比率从 1975 年的 113.5 下降到了 1976 年的 107.4。伯克希尔的保险业务部门作为一个整体，其业绩改善的幅度更大，综合费用率从 115.4 下降到了 98.7。

Our major insurance sector in insurance, the traditional auto and general liability business of National Indemnity Company, had an outstanding year, achieving profit levels significantly better than the industry generally. Credit for this performance must be given to Phil Liesche, aided particularly by Roland Miller in Underwriting and Bill Lyons in Claims. Volume at National Indemnity Company grew rapidly during 1976 as competitors finally reacted to the inadequacy of past rates. But, as mentioned in last year's annual report, we are concentrated heavily in lines that are particularly susceptible to both economic and social inflation. Thus present rates, which are adequate for today, will not be adequate tomorrow. Our opinion is that before long, perhaps in 1978, the industry will fall behind on rates as temporary prosperity produces unwise competition. If this happens, we must be prepared to meet the next wave of inadequate pricing by a significant reduction in volume.

我们保险业务的主要部门，由国民赔偿公司经营的传统的汽车险和一般责任险，在 1976 年业绩优异，比行业的平均水平要高很多。这主要归功于 Phil 的领导有方，主管承保业务的 Roland 和主管索赔业务的 Bill 也功不可没。1976 年，竞争对手终于对过去不足的保费费率做出反应，国民赔偿公司的保费收入大幅增长。但是，就像我们在去年的年报里所提到的一样，我们经验的保险业务线比较集中，且非常容易受到社会通胀和经济通胀的影响。因此，在目前的保费费率水平，能保证今年的承保业务盈利，并不能保证今后的成本业务也盈利。我们的观点是，不久以后，可能就在 1978 年，保费费率又将不足以覆盖承保成本和费用。这是因为目前承保业务盈利，将吸引大量不明智的竞争者进入。如果这种情况出现的话，我们必须对再次因保费费率定价过低导致我们的保费收入大幅下降做好准备。

Reinsurance underwriting has lagged the improvement in direct business. When mistakes are made in the pricing of reinsurance, the effects continue for even longer than when similar mistakes are made in direct underwriting. George Young, an outstanding manager, has worked tirelessly to achieve his goal of profitable underwriting, and has cancelled a great many contracts where appropriate rate adjustments were not obtainable. Here, as in the direct business, we have had a concentration in casualty lines which have been particularly hard hit by inflationary conditions. The near term outlook still is not good for our reinsurance business.

再保险业务的业绩改善落后于保险业务。当再保险业务费率定价错误的时候，它产生的影响所持续的时间要比保险业务长。George Young，我们的再保险业务经理人，一直在不知疲倦地工作，以使得我们的承保业务产生盈利。他取消了很多费率达不到要求的合同。与直接承保业务一样，我们的再保险业务也集中在意外保险产品上，非常容易受到通胀的冲击。我们再保险业务的短期前景并不太好。

Our "home state" operation continues to make substantial progress under the management of John Ringwalt. The combined ratio improved from 108.4 in 1975 to 102.7 in 1976. There still are some excess costs reflected in the combined ratio which result from the small size of several operations. Cornhusker Casualty Company, oldest and largest of the home state companies, was the winner of the Chairman's Cup in 1976 for achievement of the lowest loss ratio among the home state companies. Cornhusker also achieved the lowest combined ratio in its history at 94.4, marking the fifth time in its six full years of existence that a ratio below 100 has been recorded. Premium growth was 78% at the home state companies in 1976, as market position improved significantly. We presently plan a new home state operation later this year.

我们的 home state 保险业务（伯克希尔自己成立的四个保险公司，分别在不同的四个州经营业务，经营范围仅限于该州），在 John Ringwalt 的领导下取得巨大的进步。保险综合费用比例从 1975 年的 108.4 下降到 1976 年的 102.7。这个比率仍然包括了因为运营规模较小导致的费用较高的因素（言外之意，如果规模上去了，这个比率很可能就低于 100 了。rick）Cornhusker 意外保险公司（在内布拉斯加州经营），是我们最大，也是成立时间最长的 home state（本州）保险公司，1976 年获得了主席杯，因为其“承保损失/承保收入”的比率最低。1976 年 Cornhusker 意外保险公司的综合费用比率为 94.4，在本州保险公司中最低。这是它在 6 个完整年度中，第 5 年低于 100。1976 年，我们本州保险公司的保费收入增长率为 78%，市场地位也大幅提高。我们计划在 1977 年的晚些时候在另外一个州新开一家本州保险公司。

Our Home and Automobile Insurance Company subsidiary, writing primarily automobile business in the Cook County area of Illinois, experienced a strong recovery in 1976. This is directly attributable to John Seward who, in his first full year, has revamped significantly both rating methods and marketing. The auto business has been shifted to a six month direct bill policy, which permits a faster reaction time to underwriting trends. Our general liability business at Home and Automobile has been expanded significantly with good results. While it remains to be proven that we can achieve sustained underwriting profitability at Home and Auto, we are delighted with the progress John Seward has achieved.

家庭汽车保险公司，主要在伊州的库克县经营，在 1976 年经历了强劲的复苏。这主要归功于 John Seward，在他任上第一完整的年度里，他对保费费率的计算

和市场营销做了重大的修改。汽车保险已经转变成 6 个月的保单（以前的保单周期覆盖的是一年？rick），这将导致对承保的趋势反应更为迅速。我们在家庭汽车保险公司经营的一般责任险业务，在 1976 年大举扩张，且业绩良好。虽然家庭汽车保险公司能否持续地取得承保利润还需要时间来证明，但是我们对 John Seward 取得的成就还是感到很欣慰。

Overall, we expect a good year in insurance in 1977. Volume is high and present rate levels should allow profitable underwriting. Longer term, however, there are significant negatives in the insurance picture. Auto lines, in particular, seem highly vulnerable to pricing and regulatory problems produced by political and social factors beyond the control of individual companies.

总体而言，我们期待 1977 年有个好的年成。保费收入高，且目前的保费费率意味着承保业务将是盈利的。长期而言，保险行业还是有一些重大的负面因素会起作用。特别是在汽车险方面，由政治因素和社会因素导致的监管问题和定价问题很容易对行业造成冲击。而且，这两个因素并非企业能够控制。

Insurance Investments

Pre-tax investment income in 1976 improved to \$10,820,000 from \$8,918,000 as invested assets built up substantially, both from better levels of profitability and from gains in premium volume. In recent reports we have noted the unrealized depreciation in our bond account, but stated that we considered such market fluctuations of minor importance as our liquidity and general financial strength made it improbable that bonds would have to be sold at times other than those of our choice.

保险投资业务

税前投资收益从 1975 年的 892 万美元上升到 1976 年的 1082 万美元，主要原因是保费收入上涨，同时投资收益率也有所上升。在过去几年的年报中，我们提到我们的债券账户有未实现的摊销，同时我们也说过我们认为目前的市场波动对我们来说并不重要。我们的流动性很好，财务实力也很强，不太可能出现我们被迫出售债券的情况。（70 年代利率大幅上涨，导致债券价格下跌。债券的现值低于面值，也许根据当时的会计准则，差额部分就是需要摊销的。如果因为某些原因需要提前出售债券，可能会确认投资亏损。对持有至到期的债券而言，是不需要摊销或确认投资亏损，因为到期的现金流是确定且不变的。rick）

The bond market rallied substantially in 1976, giving us moderate net unrealized gains at yearend in the bond portfolios of both our bank and insurance companies. This, too, is of minor importance since our intention is to hold a large portion of our bonds to maturity. The corollary to higher bond prices is that lower earnings are produced by the new funds generated for investment. On balance, we prefer a situation where our bond portfolio has a current market value less than carrying value,

but more attractive rates are available on issues purchased with newly-generated funds.

1976 年，债券市场大幅反弹。到年底的时候，我们下属银行和保险公司的债券组合都产生了一定的未实现的收益。这对我们来说并不重要，因为我们会持有大部分债券组合至到期。更高的债券价格会降低我们新进的可用于投资的保费收入的收益率。总体而言，我们偏好这样的情形：我们持有债券市值低于面值。这样新的可用于投资的保险资金的收益率将更高。

Last year we stated that we expected 1976 to be a year of realized capital gains and, indeed, gains of \$9,962,000 before tax, primarily from stocks, were realized during the year. It presently appears that 1977 also will be a year of net realized capital gains. We now have a substantial unrealized gain in our stock portfolio as compared to a substantial unrealized loss several years ago. Here again we consider such market fluctuations from year to year relatively unimportant; unrealized appreciation in our equity holdings, which amounted to \$45.7 million at yearend, has declined by about \$5 million as this is written on March 21st.

去年我们曾经说过我们期待 1976 年我们将实现资本利得，实际上，我们从股票里实现了约 996 万美元的税前资本利得。以目前的情形来看，1977 年我们也将有资本利得。相对于过去几年我们有大量未实现的投资亏损，现在我们的股票组合有大量的未实现的资本利得。在这里，我们再次强调我们认为年复一年股票市场的波动相对来说并不重要。在去年年底，我们的股票组合未实现的投资收益约为 4570 万美金，到我写这份年报的时候（3 月 21 日），下降了约 500 万美金。

However, we consider the yearly business progress of the companies in which we own stocks to be very important. And here, we have been delighted by the 1976 business performance achieved by most of our portfolio companies. If the business results continue excellent over a period of years, we are certain eventually to achieve good financial results from our stock holdings, regardless of wide year-to-year fluctuations in market values.

然而，我们所购股票后面所代表的公司，其每年的盈利情况却是很重要的。1976 年，我们股票组合里大多数公司的业绩表现都令人满意。[如果这些上市公司的业绩在几年里持续表现优异，我们相信我们持有的股票组合将有很好的表现，无论股票市场每年有多大的变动。](#)

Our equity holdings with a market value of over \$3 million on December 31, 1976 were as follows:

You will notice that our major equity holdings are relatively few. We select such investments on a long-term basis, weighing the same factors as would be involved in the purchase of 100% of an operating business:

- (1) favorable long-term economic characteristics;
- (2) competent and honest management;
- (3) purchase price attractive when measured against the yardstick of value to a private owner; and
- (4) an industry with which we are familiar and whose long-term business characteristics we feel competent to judge.

1976 年，我们持股市值在 300 万美元以上的股票如下：

（我们找到的英文原文里此处省略）

你会发生我们的持股数量不多。我们用一个长期的视角来选择这些投资标的，而且我们像购买一个公司 100% 股份那样思考投资的要素：

- （1）长期的优秀的经济特征（高深的护城河）；
- （2）能力强且诚实的管理团队；
- （3）以一个 PE 投资者的标准来说便宜的购买价格；
- （4）处于一个我们熟悉的行业，且我们有能力判断公司的长期经济特征（护城河）

It is difficult to find investments meeting such a test, and that is one reason for our concentration of holdings. We simply can't find one hundred different securities that conform to our investment requirements. However, we feel quite comfortable concentrating our holdings in the much smaller number that we do identify as attractive.

找到这样的投资机会很难，这也是我们集中投资的一个原因。我们找不到 100 个股票满足我们的投资要求。幸好，我们对集中持有少数我们认为有吸引力的股票也很满意。

Our intention usually is to maintain equity positions for a long time, but sometimes we will make a purchase with a shorter expected time horizon such as Kaiser Industries. Here a distribution of securities and cash from the parent company is expected to be initiated in 1977. Purchases were made in 1976 after the announcement of the distribution plan by Kaiser management.

通常我们会持有一个公司的股权很长的时间，但有时我们也会收购某个公司的股权，然后只在一段特定的时间内持股这个公司的股权，比如 Kaiser Industries。1976

年这个公司的管理层宣布将公司的现金和证券分给股东之后，我们开始收购这个公司的股权。我们预计现金和证券的分配在 1977 年开始。

Banking

Eugene Abegg, Chief Executive of Illinois National Bank and Trust Company of Rockford, Illinois, our banking subsidiary, continues to lead the parade among bankers—just as he has even since he opened the bank in 1931. Recently, National City Corp. of Cleveland, truly an outstandingly well-managed bank, ran an ad stating "the ratio of earnings to average assets was 1.34% in 1976 which we believe to be the best percentage for any major banking company." Among the really large banks this was the best earnings achievement but, at the Illinois National Bank, earnings were close to 50% better than those of National City, or approximately 2% of average assets.

银行业务

Eugene，伊州银行的 CEO，继续带领我们的银行在全国保持领先。他在 1931 年创立了这家银行，从那时开始一直是银行的 CEO。最近，克利夫兰国民城市银行，这是一家很优秀、管理也很好的银行，做了一个广告，广告上说：“1976 年我们银行的 ROA 为 1.34%，我们相信在主要的大银行中，这个业绩是最好的。”在大型银行中，这确实是最好的业绩，但是伊州国民银行的业绩比克利夫兰国民城市银行还要好 50%，我们的 ROA 达到了约 2%（以年内平均资产计算）。（巴菲特曾提到这个银行的净利润/平均存款约为 2.1-2.2%，看来这个银行存款占总资产的比重在九成以上。rick）

This outstanding earnings record again was achieved while:

- (1) paying maximum rates of interest on all consumer savings instruments (time deposits now make up well over two-thirds of the deposit base at the Illinois National Bank),
- (2) maintaining an outstanding liquidity position (Federal Funds sold plus U. S. Government and Agency issues of under six months' duration presently are approximately equal to demand deposits), and
- (3) avoiding high-yield but second-class loans (net loan losses in 1976 came to about \$12,000, or .02% of outstanding loans, a very tiny fraction of the ratio prevailing in 1976 in the banking industry).

这个出色的业绩是在以下情况下取得的：

- (1) 对所有的储蓄账户支付了法律所允许的最高利息，目前银行的定期存款占有所有存款的 2/3 以上；

- (2) 保持了很好的流动性（出售的联邦基金+持有的 6 个月以内的美国政府及其下属机构的债券大致等于活期存款）（不太明白为何用出售的联邦基金，rick）
- (3) 避免发放高收益，但是次等级的贷款。（1976 年的贷款损失为 1.2 万美元，占贷款总额的万分之二。和行业的平均水平相比，这是一个很低的数据）

注：根据 1970 年伯克希尔的年报，伯克希尔于 1969 年收购伊州国民银行 97.7% 的股份，该银行 1969 年的存款大约为 1 亿美金，净资产为 1700 万美金，净利润约 200 万美金。ROE 仅为 12%，虽然 ROA 很高，但是 ROE 却较低，原因是该银行使用的杠杆很低。从巴菲特的信中，我们可以推断出该银行除了存款以外，其他的负债很少。也就是说其杠杆（总资产/净资产）大约为 7 倍。目前中国银行业的杠杆大约为 16-17 倍，而美国银行业的杠杆大约为 10-12 倍。

Cost control is an important factor in the bank's success. Employment is still at about the level existing at the time of purchase in 1969 despite growth in consumer time deposits from \$30 million to \$90 million and considerable expansion in other activities such as trust, travel and data processing.

成本控制是保证银行经营成功的重要因素。从 1969 年以来（到 1976 年），居民的定期存款从 3000 万美金增长到了 9000 万美金，银行在信托、旅行（支票）和数据处理方面也有长足的进展，而员工总数却保持了稳定，几乎无增长。

从巴菲特对伊州国民银行的论述来看，这个银行的几个重要特征是：

- (1) 看重居民存款，无论活期还是定期，愿意支付最高的利息来获取。对货币市场的大额存单无兴趣。估计银行看重的是居民存款的稳定性
- (2) 严格控制信用风险，避免发放高收益低等级的贷款
- (3) 保持良好的流动性，较少使用同业拆借
- (4) 严格控制成本

从前面两个特点来看，中国的国有大银行和招行符合这个特征。

Blue Chip Stamps

During 1976 we increased our interest in Blue Chip Stamps, and by yearend we held about 33% of that company's outstanding shares. Our interest in Blue Chip Stamps is of growing importance to us. Summary financial reports of Blue Chip Stamps are contained in the footnotes to our attached financial statements. Moreover, shareholders of Berkshire Hathaway Inc. are urged to obtain the current and subsequent annual reports of Blue Chip Stamps by requesting them from Mr. Robert

H. Bird, Secretary, Blue Chip Stamps, 5801 South Eastern Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90040.

蓝带印花公司

1976 年，我们增加了我们在蓝带印花公司的持股比例，年末的时候我们的持股比例为大约 33%。在蓝带印花公司的持股对我们来说越来越重要。在我们年报的附注里有蓝带印花公司的财务报表。而且我们希望伯克希尔的股东去向公司秘书伯德先生索取蓝带印花公司的年报，地址是：5801 South Eastern Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90040.

Miscellaneous

K & W Products has performed well in its first year as a subsidiary of Berkshire Hathaway Inc. Both sales and earnings were up moderately over 1975. We have less than four years remaining to comply with requirement that our bank be divested by December 31, 1980. We intend to accomplish such a divestiture in a manner that minimizes disruption to the bank and produces good results for our shareholders. Most probably this will involve a spin-off of bank shares in 1980. We also hope at some point to merge with Diversified Retailing Company, Inc. Both corporate simplification and enhanced ownership position in Blue Chip Stamps would be benefits of such a merger. However, it is unlikely that anything will be proposed in this regard during 1977.

其他事项

1976 年，伯克希尔收购了 K&W 公司（一个汽车零部件生产企业，rick），在收购当年业绩表现不错，收入和利润同比均有增长。根据相关规定和要求，我们必须在 1980 年 12 月 31 日以前将伊州国民银行分拆出去，目前只剩下不到 4 年的时间。我们期望以一种对银行的经营影响最小，且最大化股东利益的方式来分拆这个银行。目前看来最大的可能性是将银行的股份分给各位股东。我们也希望某一天与多元零售公司合并，这样的合并会简化公司结构，并提高我们在多元零售公司的持股比例。然而，在 1977 年这两件事情不会有什么进展。

Warren E. Buffett, Chairman

March 21, 1977